John Christian, Sunnyvale official who helped create Baylands Park

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BY TRACY SEIPEL
Mercury News Staff Writer

It was mid-September 1969 and John Christian was interviewing for his first big job out of college with the Hennepin County Park Reserve District in Minnesota.

His mission: to impress future boss and mentor, park superintendent Clifton French, and land the position of administrative assistant.

Not to worry, French recalled. "He was so darned good, he didn't need much mentoring. He was top-notch," said the retired superintendent, who still chuckles over his favorite memory of the day.

Part of the interview involved an automobile tour of the regional park system with French and another associate. As fate would have it, the car became mired in the soft, sandy shore of the Crow River.

Dressed in a business suit and tie, Mr. Christian "had the good grace," as French put it, to jump out and help the others push the car to dry ground.

"I had egg on my face. I was wondering what he was thinking of *me*," admitted French, who talked later with his associate about the bright, young prospect. Said French: "How could we help *not* hiring him after the way we'd treated him?"

Always willing to help

Smart, easy-going and always willing to lend a hand were among the dozens of qualities friends and associates remember about Sunnyvale's director of parks and recreation, who died Aug. 8 of prostate cancer. He was 50.

To colleagues around the state and even the country, Mr. Christian was known as a visionary in parks and recreation management. During his eight-year tenure in Sunnyvale, Mr. Christian left a legacy that City Manager Tom Lewcock, a close friend, said will be enjoyed by untold generations to come. Included are the city's most recent expansions in public open space, self-funded recreation programs, and the development of Sunnyvale's Baylands Park.

To friends at Homestead High School, attended by both his children, Mr. Christian will be remembered for his leadership and fund-raising efforts for the school's Music Boosters Club.

And in his community, he will be remembered as this year's recipient of the Distinguished Citizen of the Year Award, accepted on his behalf by his son, Cory, at a May 9 civic ceremony.

"My Dad chose as his life's work . . . as his profession . . . the pursuit of happiness," Cory told a crowd of 400, including his father seated in a wheelchair nearby.

'The pursuit of happiness'

"As a young man, he found great enjoyment in making the lives of others better. As Dad got older, the stakes became higher. But, nonetheless, his fundamental purpose of life remains the same: that being helping make the lives of Sunnyvale people that much more enjoyable. Call it the pursuit of happiness."

Born in Elmhurst, Ill., Mr. Christian got his start in parks and recreation while overseeing a Little League program in Beloit, Wis., as a teen-ager. From there, he took on a summer youth recreation program run by the city of Beloit, which sparked his interest in recreation and municipal government.

He went on to receive his bachelor's degree in recreation and park administration from the University of Wisconsin, La-Crosse, his master's in the same field from Indiana University, and a doctorate in education from the University of Minnesota.

By the time he was hired by Lewcock in 1988, Mr. Christian had spent almost 19 years in his chosen field, rising from administrative assistant to chief of operations of the Suburban Hennepin Regional Park District.

In a recent Mercury News article, Mr. Christian said he was particularly proud of his work leading to the opening of Baylands Park — for decades a vast, raw open space that was transformed with his help in 1994 into 177 acres of protected wetlands and recreation space.

"We still don't know and appreciate the impact and value of that open space in Sunnyvale," said Mr. Christian. "There is still so much potential for the use of that park for environmental and educational uses. We haven't maximized it by a long shot."

■ **Born:** June 20, 1946 in Elmhurst, Ill.
■ **Died:** Aug. 8, 1996, Sunnyvale, Calif.
■ **Survived by:** Wife, Carolyn; son, Cory; and daughter, Kelsey. ■ **Services:** Have been held in Algonquin, Ill. A local memorial service will be at 7:30 p.m. Tuesday at St. Luke Lutheran Church, 1025 The Dalles, Sunnyvale.
■ **Memorial:** Donations can be made in John Christian's name to the Sunnyvale Youth Opportunity Fund, c/o Barbara Donaldson, Sunnyvale Department of Parks and Recreation, Box 3707, Sunnyvale, Calif. 94088; Homestead High School Music Boosters, c/o Leslie Roberts, 1386 Bedford Drive, Sunnyvale, Calif. 94087; St. Luke Lutheran Church, 1025 The Dalles, Sunnyvale, Calif. 94087.